

Learning to stay, learning to win

Doubted, dropped and pushed to the brink, **Shafali Verma's rise** from the abyss to World Cup glory is a story of grit, growth and self-belief.

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Recently, Shafali Verma went on her first ever vacation: a trip to Bali with her family to wind down after a whirlwind few months of monumental achievements on the field and unending celebrations off it. Four to five days of keeping the world away followed, during which the Verma family could finally sit down and soak in the enormity of what had unfolded a few weeks earlier — India bringing home the women's ODI World Cup trophy it had yearned for far too long. "Indians are everywhere, so people kept coming up to me and congratulating me. I enjoyed it a lot," Shafali told *Sportstar*, admitting that it was on foreign soil that the historic triumph truly sank in.

The celebrations closed an important loop in a year that began on torrid terms for the 21-year-old. At the end of 2024, the explosive but inconsistent opening batter was sent back from the national ODI side to the ravines of the domestic circuit, seemingly having run out of rope. She amassed runs at will across white-ball formats, but her Team A side lost to Team C in the BCCI Senior Women's One-Day Challenger Trophy final that went down to the wire at the MA Chidambaram Stadium in Chennai in January 2025. This was weeks after her father had suffered a heart attack. As journalists ushered players from different teams into pockets for quick interviews, Shafali was spotted unsuccessfully fighting back tears

Matter of patience: Shafali Verma's risk-free approach in the ODI World Cup, especially curbing her aerial instincts early in an innings, paid rich dividends. PICS: GETTY IMAGES

